

can write those off too. He also suggested I keep track of visits to Office Depot and Staples because those are often work related as well.

DONATIONS

I currently donate to several causes. (Thanks so much, 2016 election!) I give to the LA LGBT Center, Standing Rock, Planned Parenthood, and several individual medical GoFundMes. You can write off donations, but Dan said mine would have to add up to \$6,800 altogether in order for them to make a difference (this threshold number is different for everyone, and subject to change as Trump's new tax plan goes into effect). I'm shocked to see that the GoFundMes I donate to are not tax deductible because the IRS recognizes only "qualified charitable organizations." Instead, most GoFundMe donations are considered "personal gifts." (What the hell?)

TaxGirl writer Kelly Erb wrote in a column from 2015: "If you're not sure whether an organization is qualified, ask to see their letter from the Internal Revenue Service (IRS): many organizations will actually post their letters on their website."

BE READY FOR THIS TO TAKE A WHILE

I sat with Dan for a half day working on my taxes the first time, and since then have spent even more time with him, poring over receipts and bank statements. (I see floating numbers around his face in my nightmares.) Getting into the weeds of your spending like this takes hours to do, but it's worth it since it can save you a lot of cash money, some of which you can then spend on a bottle of wine to heal you from the trauma of doing your taxes. The better organized you are, the easier this process will be each year.

